Certificate of Action: A Trust Primitive for Verifiable Autonomous Legal AI Agent Workflows

It proves what the agent did — ***not whether the agent was right.*** *Those are two different jobs.*

Your AI reviewed the contract. You can't cross-examine a log.

Delegating the task to an agent doesn't delegate the duty. When the decision is challenged, a mutable log and your word won't survive a hostile reading. The Certificate of Action turns the run into evidence — sealed when it happens.

WHAT THE CERTIFICATE CAPTURES — FOUR CHAINED LAYERS

Decision chain	What each agent did, the model + version, and the policy it operated under.
Consensus	Multi-agent review across independent reasoning passes — agreement rate and dissent.
Human review	Who reviewed, when, and on what basis — or that no one did.
Execution	The output, sealed to the decision that produced it.

SCOPE & STANDARDS

It uses the same legal foundations courts already accept for electronic records (eIDAS, FRE 902). EU AI Act record-keeping for high-risk systems takes effect **Dec 2, 2027**.

AN AGENTIC GOVERNANCE STANDARD

What should a record be required to make verifiable? Four criteria: **(1)** sequence integrity, **(2)** operating policy version, **(3)** human review at gates, **(4)** proof of when and who, strong enough to stand up as evidence.

OPEN PROBLEMS THIS ADDRESSES

- **Completeness, not just integrity.** Tamper-evidence protects what was sealed — it says nothing about what was never sealed. For workflows one party runs unsupervised, what stops them sealing only the favorable run?
- **Who audits the auditor.** The chain proves a sealed record wasn't altered — not that the issuer is independent of the party it certifies.
- **Privilege-preserving abstraction.** How much reasoning to record without exposing protected analysis. Record too little and the audit loses value; too much and privilege is at risk.

THE CRYPTOGRAPHIC SEAL — NO NEW PRIMITIVES

`SHA-256` hash chain

`X.509` PKI identity

`RFC 3161` trusted timestamp

`RFC 6962` verifiable log (Certificate Transparency)

Modify any entry and every downstream hash breaks. Only the root hash is public — a third party can confirm a record was sealed, when, and by whom **without ever seeing its contents**, and verify it is unaltered once the record is produced — all without the platform's cooperation.

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